

Session 29: The Image of God in the Storyline of the Bible

Key Takeaways

- Daniel 7 is a meditation on Genesis 1-3, where humans give up their role as embodied divine rulers to an animal. They'd rather trust in themselves than in God. And by doing so, they become like beasts.
- Genesis 3:15 gives us hope in the form of a coming seed, who we learn will be the Messiah or anointed one. In the New Testament, "Christ" means "anointed one." So Jesus is depicted as the true human and image of God, the seed of Genesis 3:15.

The Image of God in the Storyline of the Hebrew Bible

In Genesis 1:26-28, we are told that humanity, male and female together, constitute the royal image of God. God appoints humanity to rule the world on his behalf and receive his blessing as they multiply in a land of abundance.

Genesis 1 is a template for the entire biblical story. This first chapter shows us God's ideal design for his world: royal human partners, the kings and queens of creation, ruling together in an abundant world during the eternal seventh-day rest.

Genesis 2-5 tells us about the first human characters who are given the opportunity to rule together as God's image. Unfortunately, these humans foolishly forfeit their divine roles. They are deceived by a snake and choose to define good and bad on their own terms instead of acting "in the fear of Yahweh."

In Genesis 3:14-15, God says he is going to humiliate the snake ("you will eat dust all the days of your life," Gen. 3:14) and that a "seed of the woman" is going to "strike" the snake's head one day while the snake strikes the heel of the woman's seed (Gen. 3:15).

Genesis 5:1-3 shows us that this promised line of the seed will be carried on through Seth, Adam and Eve's third son.

Genesis 5:1-3 Instructor's Translation

¹ This is the scroll of the generations of 'adam: In the day when God created Adam, in the likeness of God he made him, ² male and female he created them, and he blessed them and he named them 'adam in the day when they were created. ³ And Adam had lived one hundred and thirty years, and he became the father of a son **in his own likeness, according to his image**, and named him Seth.

Notice that 'adam's relationship to God is described as "image and likeness," which recalls all of the meaning and significance of Genesis 1:26-28. Now, here in Genesis 5:1-3, Seth is described as his father's image and

likeness on analogy to Adam’s relationship to God.

The analogy illuminates in both directions.

- 1. If Seth is the “son of Adam” and can be called the image of Adam, then ‘adam too can be thought of as the “son of God,” which becomes a synonym for “image of God.”

Bonus: Notice that Luke’s genealogy of Jesus is constructed on this very conviction, tracing Jesus as “son of God” all the way back to Adam as “son of God” (see [Luke 3:23-38](#)).

- 2. Since ‘adam (consisting of male and female) was the image of God called to represent God in the world, Seth and his descendants are also identified with the promise of Genesis 3:14-15. This promise describes a future seed who will subdue the snake, rule the world on God’s behalf, and undo what happened in Genesis 3:1-7.

Bonus: The connection between a future seed of the woman and the victory over the snake is exactly how the apostles came to see Jesus as the victor over death (see [1 John 3:7-8](#)).

These ideas in Genesis 1-5 are the template for later narratives in the Hebrew Bible that show human rulers as new Adams who are given the chance to be images of God, rule the world on God’s behalf, and overcome the forces of animal-like chaos in the world.

The High Priest Is the Image of God: Exodus 25-40

“In Israel’s temple and tabernacle, the role of the cult statue is played by the high priest who is the visible and concrete image of the creator within the temple as microcosm.”

Fletcher-Louis, Crispin (2004). “God’s Image, His Cosmic Temple, and the High Priest: Towards an Historical and Theological Account of the Incarnation.” *Heaven on Earth: The Temple in Biblical Theology*. Paternoster. 89.

God in Genesis 1	The High Priest in Exodus	Implication
Creation takes place in seven days marked by seven divine acts of speech (Gen. 1:1-2:3).	The tabernacle blueprints are revealed in seven acts of divine speech (Exod. 25-31).	The tabernacle is a micro-cosmos of the world created in Genesis 1.
God’s divine light separates between darkness and light, evening and morning (Gen. 1:3-5).	Aaron is to light the menorah every evening and morning, to create light in the tabernacle (Exod. 27:20-21; 30:7-8).	The priest plays the role of the creator on the cultic stage, recreating God’s work of the first day.
Genesis 1 and the High Priest in Exodus. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2020).		

God in Genesis 1	The High Priest in Exodus	Implication
God introduced “light” (אור) into creation, which is “completed” on the seventh day.	The high priest is ordained in a seven-day ceremony where he wears the golden ephod with the stones of “lights” (אורים) and “completions” (תמים) (Exod. 28:6-30).	The high priest in his radiant clothing is the embodiment of God's light and power to bring complete order to creation.
Genesis 1 and the High Priest in Exodus. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2020).		

Joshua as a New Moses: Joshua 1-12

Joshua is portrayed as a new Moses leading Israel into the Eden-like promised land. He is called to confront the forces of evil in the land and follow God’s wisdom as defined by the Torah.

Joshua 1:1-8 NASB

¹ Now it came about after the death of Moses the servant of the LORD, that the LORD spoke to Joshua the son of Nun, Moses’ servant, saying, ² “Moses my servant is dead; now therefore arise, cross this Jordan, you and all this people, to the land which I am giving to them, to the sons of Israel. ³ Every place on which the sole of your foot treads, I have given it to you, just as I spoke to Moses. ⁴ From the wilderness and this Lebanon, even as far as the great river, the river Euphrates, all the land of the Hittites, and as far as the Great Sea toward the setting of the sun will be your territory. ⁵ **No one will be able to stand before you** all the days of your life. Just as I have been with Moses, I will be with you; I will not fail you or forsake you. ⁶ Be strong and courageous, for you shall give this people possession of the land which I swore to their fathers to give them. ⁷ Only be strong and very courageous; be careful to do according to all the Torah which Moses my servant commanded you; do not turn from it to the right or to the left, so that you may have success/wisdom wherever you go. ⁸ This scroll of the Torah shall not depart from your mouth, but you shall meditate on it day and night, so that you may be careful to do according to all that is written in it; for then you will make your way prosperous, and then you will have **success/wisdom.**”

In Joshua 2-8, we see the Jordan, Jericho, and Ai episodes. Joshua leads the Israelites to victory over Jericho by imitating God’s creation strategy from Genesis 1 (six days of work and one day of rest).

Joshua 6:1-20 NASB

¹ Now Jericho was tightly shut because of the sons of Israel; no one went out and no one came in. ² The LORD said to Joshua, “See, I have given Jericho into your hand, with its king and the valiant warriors. ³ You shall **march around the city**, all the men of war **circling the city once. You shall do so for six days.** ⁴ Also seven priests shall carry **seven trumpets** of rams’ horns before the ark; then **on the seventh day you shall march around the city seven times**, and the priests shall blow the trumpets. ⁵ It shall be that when they make a long blast with the ram’s horn, and when you hear the sound of the trumpet, all the people shall shout with a great shout; and the wall of the city will fall down flat, and the people will go up every man

straight ahead.” ...¹² Now Joshua rose early in the morning, and the priests took up the ark of the LORD.¹³ The **seven priests carrying the seven trumpets** of rams’ horns before the ark of the LORD went on continually, and blew the trumpets; and the armed men went before them and the rear guard came after the ark of the LORD, while they continued to blow the trumpets.¹⁴ Thus **the second day** they marched around the city once and returned to the camp; **they did so for six days.**¹⁵ Then **on the seventh day** they rose early at the dawning of the day and **marched around the city in the same manner seven times; only on that day they marched around the city seven times.**¹⁶ **At the seventh time,** when the priests blew the trumpets, Joshua said to the people, “Shout! For the LORD has given you the city.” ...²⁰ So **the people shouted, and priests blew the trumpets; and when the people heard the sound of the trumpet, the people shouted with a great shout and the wall fell down flat,** so that the people went up into the city, every man straight ahead, and they took the city.

Two failure narratives follow right after Joshua’s victory over Jericho. Achan takes forbidden plunder (Josh. 7), and Joshua is deceived by the Gibeonites before overcoming the alliances of kings (Josh. 9-10).

Joshua 9:1-4 NASB

¹ Now it came about when all the kings who were beyond the Jordan, in the hill country and in the lowland and on all the coast of the Great Sea toward Lebanon, the Hittite and the Amorite, the Canaanite, the Perizzite, the Hivite and the Jebusite, heard of it,² that they gathered themselves together with one accord to fight with Joshua and with Israel.³ When the inhabitants of Gibeon heard what Joshua had done to Jericho and to Ai,⁴ they also **acted craftily** and set out as envoys, and took worn-out sacks on their donkeys, and wineskins worn-out and torn and mended ...

Joshua 9:14-15 NASB

¹⁴ So the men of Israel took some of their provisions, **and did not ask for the counsel of the LORD.**¹⁵ And Joshua made peace with them and made a covenant with them, to let them live; and the leaders of the congregation swore an oath to them.

Joshua 9:22-25 NASB

²² Then Joshua called for them and spoke to them, saying, “**Why have you deceived us,** saying, ‘We are very far from you,’ when you are living within our land?”²³ **Now therefore, you are cursed,** and you shall never cease being slaves, both hewers of wood and drawers of water for the house of my God.”²⁴ So they answered Joshua and said, “Because it was certainly told your servants that the LORD your God had commanded his servant Moses to give you all the land, and to destroy all the inhabitants of the land before you; therefore **we feared greatly** for our lives because of you, and have done this thing.”²⁵ Now behold, **we are in your hands; do as it seems good and right in your eyes to do to us.”**

Joshua 10:23-25 NASB

²³ They did so, and brought these five kings out to him from the cave: the king of Jerusalem, the king of Hebron, the king of Jarmuth, the king of Lachish, and the king of Eglon.²⁴ When they brought these kings out to Joshua, Joshua called for all the men of Israel, and said to the chiefs of the men of war who had gone with him, “**Come near, put your feet on the necks of these kings.**” So they came near and put their feet on

their necks.²⁵ Joshua then said to them, “**Do not fear or be dismayed! Be strong and courageous, for thus the LORD will do to all your enemies with whom you fight.**”

Joshua Is the Template for the “Blessed One” in Psalm 1

The “blessed one” of Psalm 1 is portrayed, like the ideal Joshua in Joshua 1:7-8, as someone who mediates on the Torah day and night, which results in success and prosperity.

Psalm 1:1-6 NASB

¹ How blessed is the man

who does not walk in the counsel of the wicked,
nor stand in the path of sinners,
nor sit in the seat of scoffers!

² But his delight is in the law of the LORD,
and in his law he **meditates** day and night.

³ He will be like a tree firmly planted by streams of water,
which yields its fruit in its season
and its leaf does not wither;
and in whatever he does, he prospers.

⁴ The wicked are not so,
but they are like chaff which the wind drives away.

⁵ Therefore the wicked will not stand in the judgment,
nor sinners in the assembly of the righteous.

⁶ For the LORD knows the way of the righteous,
but the way of **the wicked will perish.**

Joshua Parallels God’s Anointed in Psalm 2

Psalm 2 NASB*

¹ Why are the nations in an uproar
and the peoples **meditate** a vain thing?

² The kings of the earth take their stand
and the rulers take counsel together
against the LORD and against **his anointed**, saying,

³ “Let us tear their fetters apart
and cast away their cords from us!”

⁴ He who sits in the heavens laughs,
the Lord scoffs at them.

⁵ Then he will speak to them in his anger
and terrify them in his fury, saying,

⁶ “But as for me, **I have installed my King**
upon Zion, my holy mountain.”

⁷ “I will surely tell of the decree of the LORD:

he said to me, 'You are **my Son**,
today I have begotten you.

⁸ 'Ask of me, and I will surely give **the nations as your inheritance**,
and the very ends of **the land as your possession**.

⁹ 'You shall break them with a rod of iron,
you shall shatter them like earthenware.'"

¹⁰ Now therefore, O kings, show discernment;
take warning, O judges of the earth.

¹¹ Worship the LORD with reverence
and rejoice with trembling.

¹² Do homage to the Son, that he not become angry, **and you perish in the way**,
for his wrath may soon be kindled.

How blessed are all who take refuge in him!

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

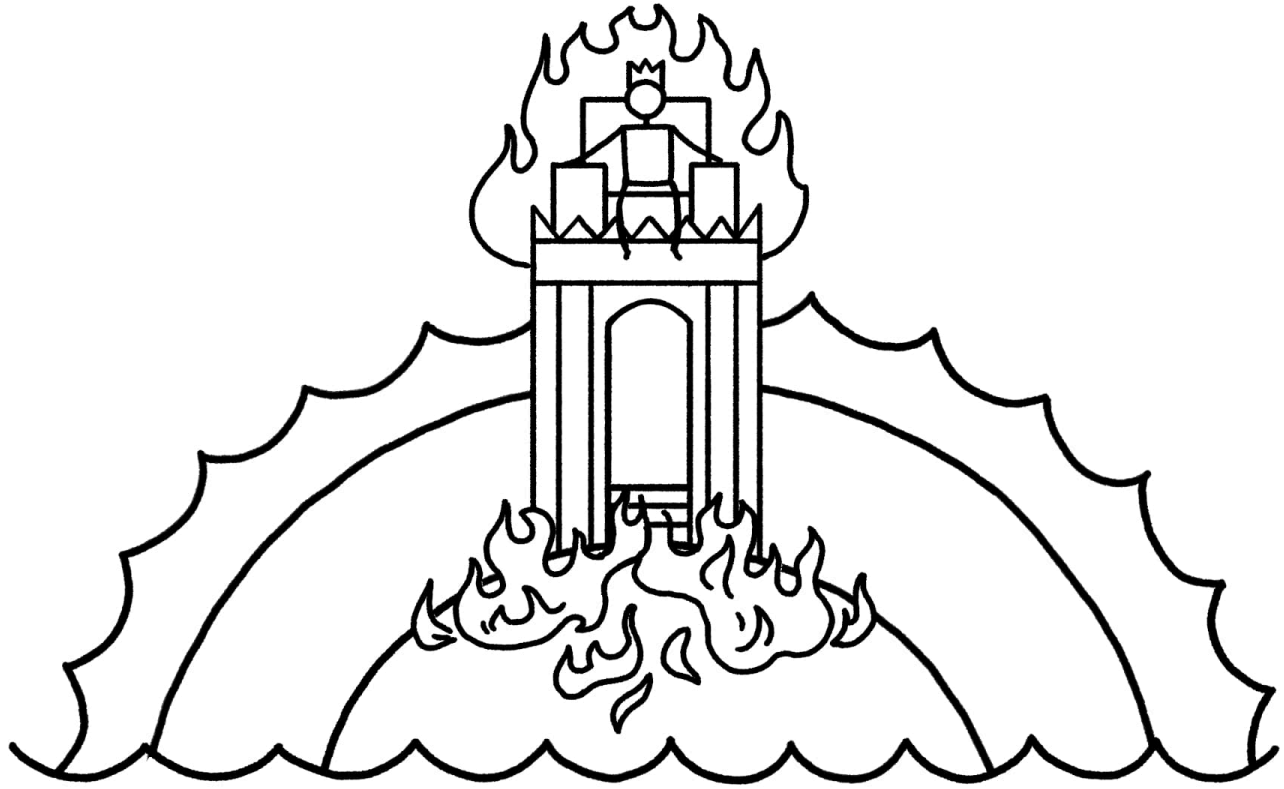
This poem depicts the rebellious nations plotting against Yahweh and his anointed just like the rebellious Canaanite kings were continuously plotting in Joshua 5-12. Joshua's "promised land" here becomes the "inheritance for the nations." The destiny of the nations turns on whether or not they will humble themselves before the anointed son of God. If not, they will "perish in the way" (just like the "way of the wicked" in Ps. 1). But if they "kiss the son" and take refuge in him, they will find God's blessing.

Daniel 7 Depicts "One Like a Son of Man" Who Is Exalted From Earth To Sit Beside God on His Heavenly Throne

In Daniel 1:1-3, we learn that Daniel is of the "royal seed" (lit. "seed of the kingdom"), that is, from the line of David. He is taken into Babylon in the first wave of exiles from Jerusalem. In Daniel 2-7, we have a fully worked out theology of the "image of God" represented by God's royal priesthood who has been exiled to the land of idolatrous royal images.



BibleProject (2016). Overview: Daniel.



The Son of Man in Daniel 9. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).

Jesus as the Image of God and Son of God

In Luke 3-4, Jesus is depicted as a new Adam, the royal and priestly Son of God.

In Colossians 1-3, Jesus is explicitly called “the image of God.” He is God’s second self, the royal and divine human who is now risen and ruling the cosmos. Notice that the new humanity of Jesus is now available to his people, so they are being renewed in the image of God as well.

Colossians 1:15-20 NIV*

¹⁵ The Son ...

who is the image of the invisible God,
the **firstborn** of all creation.

¹⁶ **For in him all things were created,**
in the heavens and on the earth,

things visible and invisible,
whether thrones or powers
or rulers or authorities—

all things have been created through him and to him.

¹⁷ **And he** is before all things, and **in him** all things hold together.

¹⁸ **And he** is head of the body, the church;

who is the beginning
the **firstborn** from the dead;

so that he himself might come to have first place in everything.

¹⁹ For **in him**, [God] was pleased that all the fullness would dwell

²⁰ and **through him to reconcile all things to himself**,

things on earth or things in heaven,

having made peace through the blood of his cross.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Colossians 3:1-4 NIV*

¹ Therefore, if you have been raised with the Messiah, set your hearts on the things above, where the Messiah is, seated at the right hand of God. ² Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things. ³ For you died, and your life is now hidden with Messiah in God. ⁴ And when the Messiah, who is your life, appears, then you also will appear with him in glory.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Colossians 3:9-11 NASB

⁹ Do not lie to each other, since you have taken off **the old humanity** with its practices ¹⁰ and you have put on **the new humanity**, which is being renewed in knowledge **in the image of its Creator**. ¹¹ Here there is no Gentile or Jew, circumcised or uncircumcised, barbarian, Scythian, slave or free, but the Messiah is all, and he is in all.

Reflection Question

Why is Daniel 7 such a significant chapter for understanding the image of God?